Court orders for refunds: Once the court verifies the claim, it may order the banks to release the frozen money to your account. However, you will be required to provide a surety equal to the refund amount, which will remain with the court until the case is settled





Surety requirement
If you fail to provide the required surety, you will not be able to recover the funds

Why speed is critical
Acting quickly ensures that as much money as possible is frozen across various accounts before it is further transferred. When multiple victims' money is in the same account, banks release funds based on the sequence of court orders. Victims with early court orders are more likely to recover their money



egorised into three levels: T1 for online betting, T2 for investment scams and T3 for more complex frauds like 'digital arrests'. The money trail often ends at cryptocurrency exchanges, routed through complex channels via financial havens like Taiwan, Dubai and others. This shift to digital assets has made the task of investigators even tougher, as cryptocurrencies bypass traditional banking systems. The scammers also exploit the delay between victims transferring the money, becoming aware of the fraud, freezing their accounts and filing

BHOPAL
DR PREETI*, 50
Professor at a medical college
**name changed*

The con: **FedEx parcel containing MDMA**

Sum lost:
Rs 40 lakh

"You're now a party to the case"

It was a summer evening and, exhausted from a long day, the doctor had just sat down with a cup of tea when the phone buzzed. The voice on the other end was calm. "Is this Dr Preeti, I'm calling from FedEx." Once she confirmed, the tone shifted. "A parcel in your name was intercepted in Mumbai. It was found to contain five passports and the drug MDMA."

The doctor froze. "That's impossible," she exclaimed. "I haven't sent any courier." The caller didn't miss a beat. "Ma'am, this is a serious matter. I'm connecting you to the Mumbai Crime Branch. You'll need to explain this directly to the police." Before she could protest, a new voice took over, introducing himself as an inspector from the Crime Branch. In the background, she heard the static of a wireless set. The last shred of doubt vanished. "Your documents were found with the package," the officer said, his tone hardening. "You're now a party to the case."

She pleaded innocence, but the 'officer' was unrelenting. "You'll need to cooperate. Your statement will be recorded online. Now, tell me—what are your bank account details? How much money do you have?" She hesitated, her instincts screaming to stop, but fear paralysed her. When he demanded she download Skype for the interrogation, she complied. "Lock yourself in a room," he ordered. "This is a sensitive matter, and we can't have any interruptions."

The screen flickered, revealing a man in uniform, his demeanour stoic and authoritative. Behind him, other officers moved purposefully, their presence lending credibility to the charade. For the next four hours, she endured a relentless interrogation. "You need to transfer all the money in your accounts—around Rs 40 lakh—to this account," he instructed, sharing the details. "The RBI will freeze your account for the duration of the investigation. This is a holding account managed by the Crime Branch. It's the only way to keep your money safe."

"Lock yourself in a room," he ordered. "This is a sensitive matter, and we can't have any interruptions"

Her rational mind knew something was off, but exhaustion, fear and hours of relentless manipulation made her do exactly what she was asked. With shaky hands, she executed the transfer. The line went dead. Numb and disoriented, the doctor stumbled out of the room. As she stepped outside, reality hit her like a freight train. She had been duped, the money gone.

-Rahul Noronha